



How Cambodia-Thailand Border “Third Clash” Will Play-Out

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Introduction

The territorial dispute between Cambodia and Thailand has entered a new phase. Contrary to expectations of a third armed confrontation, the current dynamics reveal a shift toward an endurance-based strategy, the approach that prioritizes long-term consolidation over immediate military engagement, specifically through “structural encroachment” and infrastructure expansion as the primary means of asserting sovereignty.

As Thailand calculated that armed conflict carries significant political and diplomatic costs, Thailand opted to pursue a strategy that is long-term, endurance-based consolidation strategy designed to alter facts on the ground incrementally, accumulate tactical positioning, and enter an eventual negotiation from a position of structural superiority.

This does not mean a third armed clash is categorically off the table. Thailand still has the capacity and demonstrated willingness to escalate when conditions are favorable. But the primary instrument of the current phase is not the gun, it is the military presence, the gradual extension of barbed wire and construction to consolidate territory, and the carefully managed narrative.

The Endurance Strategy: Structural Encroachment

The most underappreciated dimension of Thailand's approach is its narrative building. Thailand has invested systematically in a framing that positions Cambodia as the provocateur and a persistence threat, which provides international legitimacy for Thailand's own force expansion, casting Thai military activities as proportionate and defensive, and locks Cambodia into a reactive posture where any defensive measure Cambodia takes can be recast as evidence of escalatory intent. The asymmetry here is deliberate, where Thailand's capability expansion along the border, troop reinforcements, infrastructure construction, barbed wire emplacement, container deployments, trench monitoring, materially exceeds anything Cambodia has undertaken in proportional terms.

Official Thai government statements characterize these installations as necessary measures for "enhancing safety and security" and combating "online scam activities," while Cambodia's officials report that these same actions, specifically the placement of containers and barbed wire, block civilians from accessing their homes and constitute violations of sovereignty. Yet it is Cambodia's comparatively limited procurement and defensive measures that are consistently highlighted as indicators of dangerous escalation, with Thai security officials pointing to Cambodia's acquisition of anti-aircraft systems as evidence of a "concerning" build-up that could trigger a "third round" of hostilities, while Thailand's extensive military infrastructure expansion along the contested border and far larger advancements are presented as necessary precautions.

When a stronger party successfully establishes the perception that the weaker party is the aggressor, it does not merely win the public relations contest, it creates the conditions under which its own escalation is normalized and the weaker party's responses are pre-delegitimized. This is not balance of power politics, it is advantage accumulation through narrative asymmetry, and Thailand is executing it with some sophistication. The pattern of Thailand's political figures and most recently from Lieutenant General Theeranan Nanthakwang, Director of the Royal Thai Army Intelligence Department, issuing warnings about a potential "third clash" reinforces this architecture. These warnings are not primarily objective threat assessments, they function as strategic framing, reinforcing the image of Cambodia as a persistent security risk, legitimizing Thailand's force posture, and sending a coercive signal to Cambodia that any challenge to

Thailand's positions will be met with a "ready-to-respond" military that has already prepared its justifications.

Diplomatic Manipulation: The Dormant Joint Boundary Commission

Perhaps the most revealing element of Thailand's approach is not what it is doing militarily but what it is not doing diplomatically. The Joint Boundary Commission (JBC), the bilateral mechanism mandated to resolve demarcation disputes, has remained effectively dormant, and Thailand's management of its suspension deserves scrutiny.

Thailand has repeatedly postponed JBC meetings, with Cambodia noting that the Thai side requested delays due to "internal procedures" following elections. Prime Minister Hun Manet explicitly stated in February 2026 that Thailand had cited its February 8 election as a reason not to begin demarcation work, adding "now the election is done, we hope that Thailand can start." Thailand has conditioned JBC resumption on a sequence of prior requirements; a new government must be in place, tensions must sufficiently de-escalate, demining must be completed.

Each condition is reasonable in isolation; however, they constitute an open-ended deferral mechanism that serves Thailand's interests precisely because time is not neutral in this dispute. Every month the JBC remains inactive is a month during which Thai forces consolidate their current positions, embed infrastructure, and normalize their presence in contested areas, specific instances of this consolidation, including Thai military activities involving the laying of barbed wire, nets, barricades, and vehicle tires at boundary segments between Pillars 42-43 and 46-47 in Banteay Meanchey Province, and the approval of the construction of a permanent 10-kilometer border fence near Aranyaprathet along with triple-layer barbed wire and CCTV installations in disputed areas.

Hence, when formal demarcation negotiations eventually do occur, they will take place against a physical reality that Thailand has been actively constructing. Actually, Thailand does not need to reject the JBC process, it needs only to ensure that by the time the process resumes, the facts on the ground have materially shifted in its favor.

Narrative Asymmetry: Engineering the Security Dilemma

Classical security dilemma theory describes a dynamic in which states, uncertain of each other's intentions, take defensive measures that the other side interprets as threatening, producing a spiral of mutual escalation that neither side necessarily wants. What Thailand is doing is something more deliberate; it is not falling into a security dilemma with Cambodia; it is engineering one.

By consistently framing Cambodia's defensive measures as threatening while presenting its own substantially larger military activities as routine and proportionate, Thailand actively constructs the conditions of the security dilemma rather than responding to them organically. The effect is that Cambodia faces a structural trap; any defensive investment it makes becomes evidence of Thai threat narratives, for instance when Thai security officials highlighted Cambodia's reported procurement of "advanced anti-aircraft weaponry" as a "concerning escalation" and a sign of preparations for a "third round" of conflict, while any restraint it exercises allows Thai consolidation to proceed unchallenged.

There is no move available to Cambodia within this framing that Thailand cannot characterize as either provocative or irrelevant. The practical consequence is that Thailand can continue to expand its capabilities, infrastructure, and positional advantages while sustaining the external appearance of a party responding

cautiously to Cambodian aggression, which this is not an accident of misperception; it is the intended outcome of a deliberate narrative and operational strategy.

Conclusion

However still, this does not mean that Thailand has categorically foreclosed the option of a third armed clash. The endurance strategy and the military option are not mutually exclusive. The former builds conditions; the latter remains available when those conditions are favorable.

There are factors indicate that armed escalation remains a live possibility rather than a theoretical one, as there are specific locations along the contested border, areas not yet under Thai physical control, that represent unfinished elements of Thailand's positional agenda.

As long as those locations remain contested, the risk of a confrontation that Thailand can manage, justify under its pre-established narrative, and exploit to further its objectives remains real. The pattern of behavior since the ceasefire, container deployments, road construction initiated in disputed areas, demonstrates a consistent willingness to escalate incrementally even within the nominal ceasefire framework. The third Cambodia-Thailand border armed clash, if it comes, will not be accidental; it will be chosen.